

**Politics as a Flavoring Agent:
Moralized Demand and the Limits of Revealed Preference**

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Abstract

Consumers who will not switch phones over a manufacturer’s politics often switch beer brands over an advertisement. We attribute the asymmetry to functional convergence: when competing products have converged, political meaning can take over differentiation through two channels. Under sorting, politics changes which good is chosen and leaves its experienced quality intact; under flavoring, politics changes the experience, so the same physical good is rated better under an aligned label and worse under a misaligned one. We build a minimal model containing both channels and a mixture parameter ϕ , the flavoring share of the political premium, and solve it for 60,000 consumers. At the quality plateau the labeled market is invariant to ϕ : choice data are identical for every split, and a political premium of 0.362 functional-quality units is consistent with any ϕ in $[0, 1]$. Only the within-good difference between blind and labeled ratings, 0.202 per unit of ϕ for aligned consumers, identifies the split. Sweeping functional dispersion gives a threshold $\Delta F^* = 0.443$ below which politics decides most contested choices; ten categories placed on this axis split into bottled water through cosmetics on the flavor-dominated side and phones through medical devices on the other. With the misalignment penalty 2.33 times the alignment bonus, a mass-market brand that adopts a political position loses 0.036 of demand, where a symmetric model predicts a gain of 0.008; adoption pays only for a base centred beyond 0.415 toward the adopted pole. Market data fix the premium, threshold, and activism penalty; the flavoring share requires experimental measurement.

1. Introduction

A person who would not change a phone, a car, or a washing machine over the maker’s politics will drop a beer, a coffee, or a razor for much less, and the difference is usually attributed to price: the cheap item is easy to abandon and the expensive one is not. The same person, however, keeps the cheap items they like and abandons the cheap items that politics has touched, so price cannot account for the pattern. The phones available to the buyer differ on dimensions the buyer can perceive, and beers within a price tier do not. Where products have converged, the buyer has spare capacity to care about attributes other than function, and politics is the most available such attribute.

The claim concerns where political meaning lands in consumption; it does not assert that political consumption is new or that consumers are deceived. A large literature treats buying and boycotting as political participation (Stolle et al. 2005; Micheletti 2003), measures its prevalence and its participants (Newman and Bartels 2011; Endres and Panagopoulos 2017), distinguishes the approach motive of the boycott from the avoidance motive of the boycott (Neilson 2010; Kam and Deichert 2020), and asks when a firm’s public stance helps or hurts it (Vredenburg et al. 2020; Bhagwat et al. 2020). In that literature the boycott is the consumer’s exit, the cheapest channel of pressure when voice is costly and a substitute is available (Hirschman 1970), and politics is a reason to act. The present question is narrower: when a consumer reports that the aligned beer is better, what does “better” measure, and can market data determine it?

Two answers are available, and they are usually conflated. In the first, politics is a preference over an attribute, comparable to sweetness or a logo; the aligned beer wins the choice but tastes the same, and the consumer would say so under questioning. We call this sorting, because it sorts buyers across goods without altering the goods. In the second, politics has entered the taste, so the aligned beer is experienced as better in addition to being chosen. We call this flavoring. The two channels describe different facts that generate the same market, and Section 4 shows that market data from one market cannot separate them.

2. Background: Expectation, Contamination, and Credence Goods

That goods carry meaning beyond function is among the oldest observations in the study of consumption, from conspicuous waste as a status display (Veblen 1899) through taste as a marker of social position (Bourdieu 1984) to the brand as a vessel of cultural myth (Holt 2004). Politics is a recent entrant into that symbolic layer and continuous with it. The additional claim is that political meaning can extend from the layer of signification into the layer of experience.

Beliefs about a product change the experience of consuming it, as measured both by report and by brain activity. Subjects told that a wine is more expensive rate it as more pleasant and show higher activity in orbitofrontal regions that encode experienced pleasantness, with the wine held fixed (Plassmann et al. 2008). Subjects told before tasting that a beer contains a distinctive additive like it less, while subjects told afterwards do not, so the expectation moves the verdict independently of the chemistry (Lee et al. 2006). The route by which a price cue enters a taste can carry a political cue in the same way, and moral psychology supplies the second half of that route: moral judgment recruits the machinery of physical disgust, so a moralized object can be experienced as contaminated in addition to being disapproved of (Chapman et al. 2009; Rozin 1999). Contamination follows the laws of sympathetic magic, under which contact with a tainted source transfers the taint to a physically unchanged object (Rozin et al. 1986). A beer can acquire a political taint in the sense in which a glass is spoiled by a cockroach that briefly sat in it.

The contamination half of the route is stronger than the endorsement half. Negativity dominance is the regularity that combining a negative element with a positive one yields an outcome more negative than the parts predict, most pronounced in contagion, where a drop of sewage spoils a barrel of wine and a drop of wine does nothing for a barrel of sewage (Rozin and Royzman 2001; Baumeister et al. 2001). Applied to consumption, it predicts that political misalignment spoils a good more than alignment improves it, and the marketing evidence agrees: disagreement with a brand's stance damages attitudes more than agreement repairs them (Mukherjee and Althuizen 2020), and divisive stances are riskier for brands with more to lose (Hydock et al. 2020). The model in Section 3 encodes the asymmetry as a single ratio and derives these findings from it.

Politics enters here as a credence quality, a property the buyer cannot verify even after consumption, the class of attribute that the economics of information has studied since the analysis of uncertain and unobservable quality (Akerlof 1970; Nelson 1970). Ethical labels of this kind move real purchases as well as stated attitudes, as a multistore field experiment on fair-trade coffee showed (Hainmueller et al. 2015). The flavoring channel operates upstream of the purchase: the credence

claim can re-enter as taste in addition to tipping the choice. It is therefore distinct from cause-related marketing, in which a purchase funds a cause (Varadarajan and Menon 1988), and from commodity activism, in which resistance is routed through consumption (Banet-Weiser 2012); both change the meaning of buying, and neither claims to change how the good tastes.

Flavoring is therefore plausible and asymmetric, but it is invisible in the data economists usually examine. Revealed preference reads choices, and a choice records that the aligned beer won without recording whether it won as a preferred attribute or as a better-tasting good. Stated satisfaction does not separate the two, because a satisfied buyer may be reporting the pleasure of the taste or the pleasure of the alignment. The separation requires a measurement the market does not make: the same physical good rated once with its label and once without. Expectation experiments make that measurement, and Section 4 shows that it is the only measurement that identifies the mechanism.

3. Model

A category contains substitutable goods. Consumer i has a political position x_i on a one-dimensional axis, drawn from a polarized electorate in which half the population clusters near $-\mu$ and half near $+\mu$, reflecting the affective sorting documented in the polarization literature (Iyengar et al. 2019); here $\mu = 1$ and the within-group spread is 0.5. Good j has functional quality F_j and, if politicized, a position p_j . Alignment between a consumer and a good is the Gaussian kernel

$$a_{ij} = \exp\left(-\frac{(x_i - p_j)^2}{2\tau^2}\right) \in (0, 1],$$

equal to one when the consumer sits at the good's position and decaying to zero with distance, with $\tau = 1$. The political charge of the good for the consumer is a bonus when aligned net of a penalty when misaligned,

$$\pi_{ij} = \lambda_+ a_{ij} - \lambda_- (1 - a_{ij}),$$

with $\lambda_- \geq \lambda_+$ encoding negativity dominance. A fully aligned consumer receives $\pi = \lambda_+$ and a fully misaligned one $\pi = -\lambda_-$. The magnitudes are illustrative, anchored to published effect sizes and not estimated for any market: $\lambda_+ = 0.15$ lies in the range of the price-on-pleasantness and label-on-taste shifts, and $\lambda_- = 0.35$ sets the contamination penalty at 2.33 times the bonus, within the band reported in the negativity-dominance literature.

The two channels differ in where π enters. Under sorting it is expressive: it enters the utility that drives choice and leaves the hedonic quality the consumer would report for the good in hand unchanged. This is the orthodox reading and it is well founded: identity is a standard argument of the utility function (Akerlof and Kranton 2000), a good is a bundle of characteristics of which politics can be one (Lancaster 1966), and brands hold knowledge and relationships that drive differential

response (Keller 1993; Fournier 1998) and serve as material for the self and its reference groups (Escalas and Bettman 2005; Bhattacharya and Sen 2003; Tajfel and Turner 1979). Under flavoring π is hedonic: it multiplies experienced quality, so the good is tasted as $F_j(1 + \pi_{ij})$. The mixture parameter $\phi \in [0, 1]$ is the share of the political charge that runs through flavoring. Labeled total utility, the quantity maximized in choice, is

$$U_{ij}^{\text{lab}} = F_j + \pi_{ij}(\phi F_j + (1 - \phi)F_0),$$

where $F_0 = 1$ is the reference quality of the category. The flavoring component scales with the good's own quality F_j ; the sorting component is a fixed expressive weight scaled by F_0 . Without its label the good carries no expressive charge, so only the hedonic channel remains, and the blind and labeled hedonic ratings are

$$Q_{ij}^{\text{blind}} = F_j, \quad Q_{ij}^{\text{lab}} = F_j(1 + \phi \pi_{ij}).$$

The analysis turns on the difference between these two ratings and on one property of the utility: when competing goods share a common quality $F_j = F_0$, the bracket in U^{lab} equals F_0 for every ϕ , and total utility no longer depends on ϕ .

4. Results

4.1 The flavoring share is unidentified at the quality plateau

Place both goods at the plateau, $F_R = F_L = F_0$, at opposite political poles ($p = \pm 1$), and solve the labeled market over 60,000 consumers. To make the two goods mirror images, this study uses a symmetric political weight, $\lambda_+ = \lambda_- = 0.25$. Total labeled utility is

$$U_{ij}^{\text{lab}} = F_0(1 + \pi_{ij}),$$

which does not contain ϕ . Every consumer's choice, and therefore every market share, every revealed-preference estimate, and every difference-in-differences estimate on labeled data, is the same whether the political premium runs entirely through sorting ($\phi = 0$), entirely through flavoring ($\phi = 1$), or through any mixture. Across the ϕ grid the market share of either good changes by 0 to arithmetic precision, and adding Gumbel choice noise leaves a residual dispersion below 0.001, confirming that the invariance does not depend on exact tie-breaking. The political premium, the labeled willingness-to-pay gap between a consumer's better-matched and worse-matched good, is 0.362 in F_0 units for every ϕ .

The parameter ϕ is identified by a within-good quantity that the market does not produce. The difference between a good's labeled and blind hedonic ratings is $F_0 \phi \pi_{ij}$, linear in ϕ through the origin; averaged over consumers whose chosen good is aligned, it runs from 0 at $\phi = 0$ to 0.202 at $\phi = 1$. A relabeling experiment measures this swing by serving one physical good twice, once with

the aligning label and once blind, and recording the change in rating. No market statistic recovers it, because a market never serves the same good to the same buyer under two labels and records the hedonic difference. At the plateau the decomposition is therefore unidentified: the premium is real and its size recoverable, and the flavoring fraction can take any value in $[0, 1]$ until a blind test is run (Figure 1).

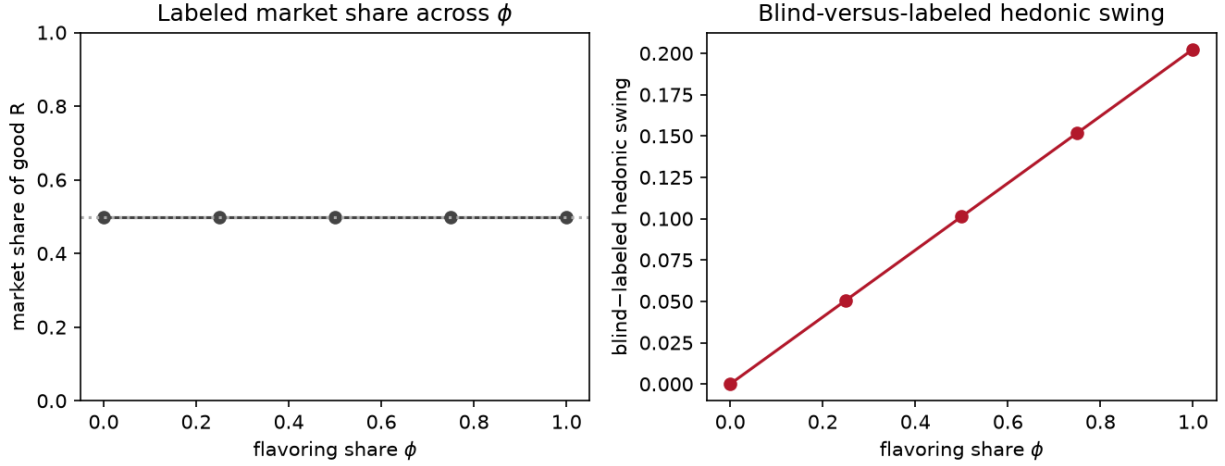


Figure 1: Identification of the flavoring share at the quality plateau. Left: market share of one good as the flavoring share ϕ varies from 0 to 1; the labeled market is invariant to ϕ , so revealed preference cannot recover the split between sorting and flavoring. Right: mean blind-versus-labeled hedonic swing for aligned consumers, linear in ϕ from 0 to 0.202. This within-good swing, measured by a relabeling experiment, is the only quantity that identifies ϕ .

The non-identification is complete at the plateau because the bracket collapses there. Away from the plateau, with $F_R \neq F_L$, the ϕ -weighted term no longer cancels, choice begins to respond to ϕ , and the mixture becomes weakly identified from how buyers trade quality against politics. The identification failure and the plateau condition are therefore the same property of the model: politics has the most influence on choice, and the least legible mechanism, where products have stopped differing.

4.2 A functional-dispersion threshold for political choice

Now let the goods differ in quality. Good R sits at the +1 pole with quality $F_0 + \Delta F/2$ and good L at the -1 pole with $F_0 - \Delta F/2$, so R is always functionally better, and politics decides a consumer's choice when the political charge moves them to L . This study uses the asymmetric weights of Section 3 and full flavoring, $\phi = 1$. Sweeping the functional dispersion ΔF from zero shows how far quality must diverge before function determines the choice. At $\Delta F = 0$ the politics-determined share is 0.501, the half of the electorate aligned to L ; it falls as the quality gap widens and L -aligned consumers switch to the better good. The share falls below one quarter of the market, half of the politically susceptible subpopulation, at $\Delta F^* = 0.443$ (located by bisection;

the grid of step 0.005 gives 0.445). Below that dispersion politics decides most contested choices, and above it function does.

Placing categories on the ΔF axis converts the threshold into a susceptibility typology. With stipulated, ordinal values for how much competing products in each category differ on perceptible dimensions, the ten categories split five and five. Bottled water ($\Delta F = 0.03$, politics-determined share 0.497), beer, coffee, fashion basics, and cosmetics (0.20, share 0.459) lie on the flavor-dominated side; phones (0.48, share 0.110), cars, televisions, industrial tools, and medical devices (0.78, share 0.000) lie on the other (Figure 2). The ordering follows from the position of each category's dispersion relative to the single threshold, and it matches the received view that politics can dominate choice of a beer and cannot dominate choice of a pacemaker.

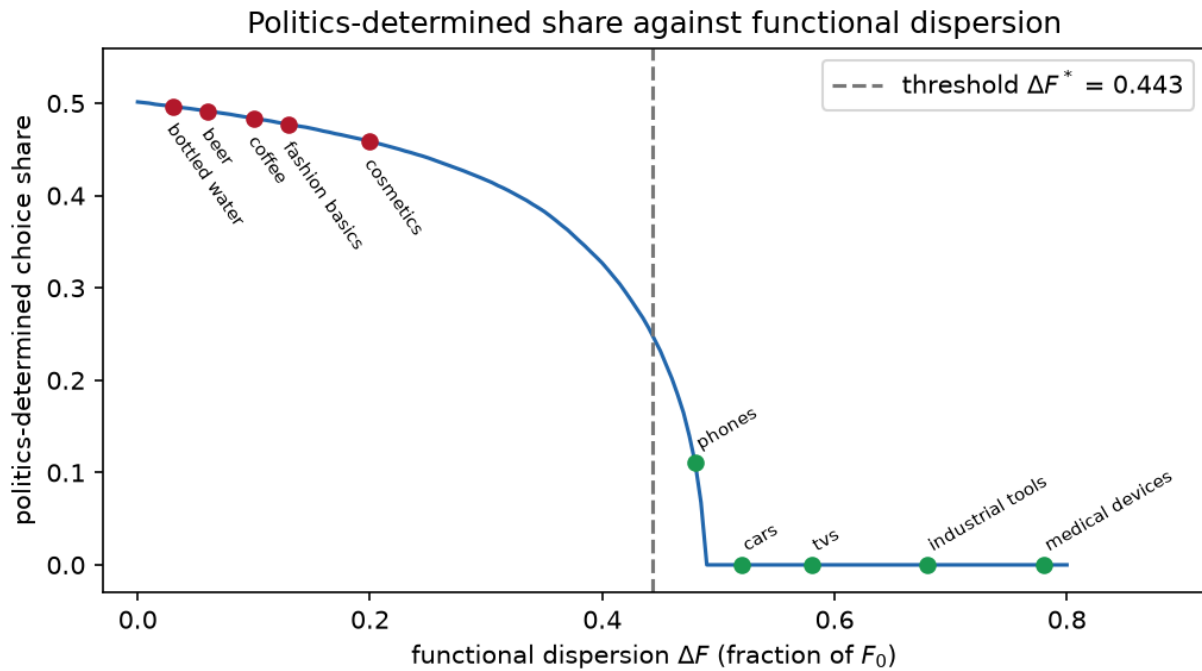


Figure 2: Politics-determined choice share against functional dispersion ΔF . The share falls from about 0.50 at the plateau to zero once quality differences are large, crossing one quarter at $\Delta F^* = 0.443$ (dashed). Ten categories are placed at stipulated, ordinal dispersions; the five below the threshold are flavor-dominated (red) and the five above it function-dominated (green).

The threshold gives a mechanism to a condition that the marketing literature names qualitatively. Commoditization is described as a drift toward homogeneity, price sensitivity, and low switching cost (Reimann et al. 2010), and the good-enough plateau is the point at which product improvement overshoots what buyers can use (Christensen 1997); the model expresses that point as the dispersion ΔF^* at which politics changes from a tiebreaker into the deciding factor. Visibility belongs on the same axis, since identity-relevant goods are those consumed in public, where others can read the label (Berger and Heath 2007); an extended model would let visibility shift the threshold.

The threshold also limits the scope of the theory. Politics can modify the experience of a good but cannot substitute for its function. A category with real, perceptible performance gaps does not become politically favorable through campaigning, because a buyer who can perceive the difference chooses on it. The plateau is a precondition, and the model expresses it as a number.

4.3 Brand activism under negativity dominance

The first two results take the goods' political positions as given. The third concerns a neutral good that acquires one. A brand with no political position serves a base distributed around some mean position (spread 0.7); it adopts the +1 pole, and each customer's logit purchase probability shifts with the political charge π now attached to the good. Because the charge is negativity-dominant, the alienated tail of the base loses more than the aligned tail gains, and whether adoption pays depends on where the base already lies.

For a mass-market brand, whose base is centred on the electorate, adoption is a loss: demand falls by 0.036. The loss is due entirely to the asymmetry. With a symmetric charge, $\lambda_- = \lambda_+$, the same centred brand gains 0.008. The penalty arises because the disagreeing half withdraws more strongly than the approving half responds, and a symmetric model would cancel the two. Adoption pays only for a base already concentrated toward the adopted pole: the demand change crosses zero at a base mean of 0.415 (bisection; the 0.025 grid gives 0.425), so brands whose customers lie beyond that point gain and broader brands lose. A challenger whose base sits at the pole gains 0.021, and a brand that adopts the pole opposite its base loses 0.138. The result reproduces the large-share-brand pattern, in which visible incumbents are penalized for stances that reward niche entrants, from the contagion asymmetry alone (Figure 3).

The size of the penalty tracks the negativity-dominance ratio. As the ratio rises from 1.0 to 4.0, the centred brand's demand change falls from +0.008 to -0.101, and the break-even base mean rises from -0.152 to beyond 1.5, the upper limit of the scanned range, so that under strong contamination no broad brand can adopt a position profitably. On this account the Bud Light episode and similar cases follow from placing one pole's politics on a good whose base spans the centre, in a category (beer) that Section 4.2 places among the most favorable, and the outcome depends little on execution.

5. Application to Public Cases

The model sorts public cases along two axes, sorting versus flavoring and discipline versus ritual. Bud Light is the clearest instance of the activism result: a commodity at the plateau, a centred mass-market base, a stance toward one pole, and a collapse made costless for boycotters by substitution, since the alienated half had many interchangeable lagers available. Nike and Kaepernick is the mirror case. The base of an apparel brand already concentrated among younger urban consumers was not centred, so the manoeuvre that damaged a centred beer brand consolidated a polarized shoe brand, as the break-even result predicts for a base beyond the threshold.

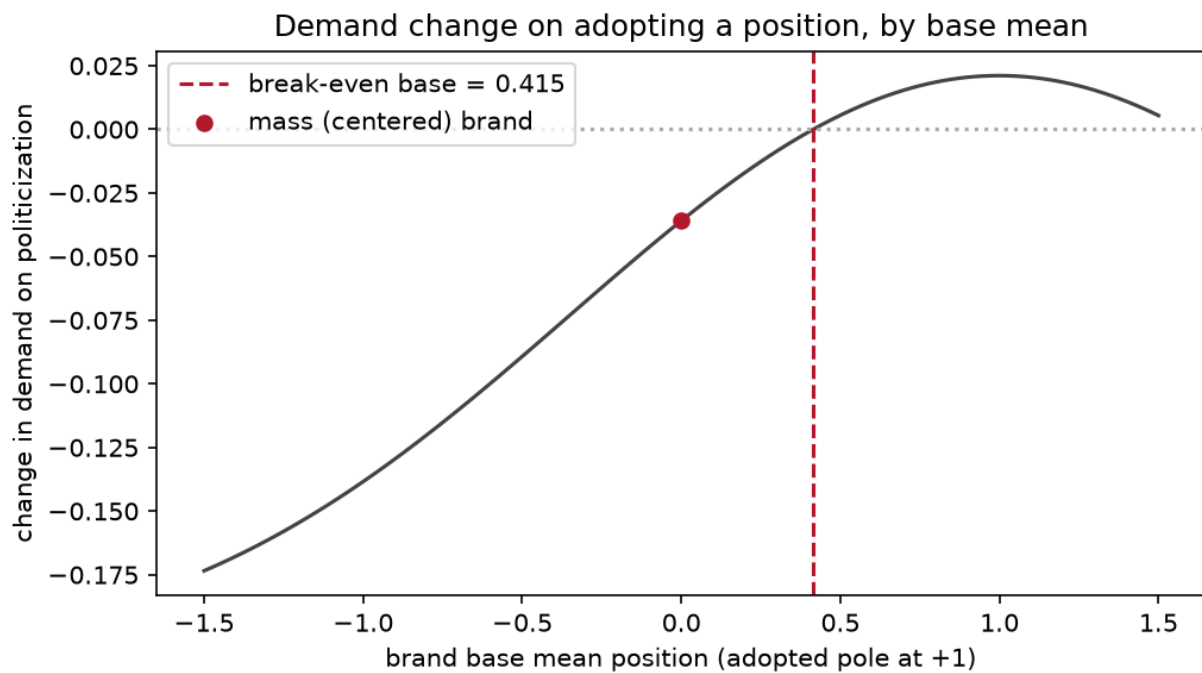


Figure 3: Change in a brand's demand when a neutral good adopts the +1 political position, against the mean position of the brand's existing base. The curve is negative for a centred mass-market base (red point, -0.036), crosses zero at a base mean of 0.415 (dashed), and is positive only for bases concentrated near the adopted pole. Under a symmetric charge the centred brand would gain; the penalty is a consequence of negativity dominance.

The discipline-versus-ritual axis separates boycotts that function as flavoring rituals from those with a material object, a distinction the boycott literature draws from several directions: participant motivation (Klein et al. 2004), the social dilemma of withholding consumption (Sen et al. 2001), media leverage as distinct from lost revenue (Friedman 1999), and the conditions under which firms respond (King 2008). The Israel-related consumer boycotts of fast-food and coffee chains operate largely through symbolic association and local franchise actions, with little supply-chain involvement, in categories the plateau result marks as favorable, and their effect concentrates where ideological alignment is densest. This is the signature of an identity ritual that stabilizes a group, a brand community defined as much by what it refuses as by what it buys (Muniz and O'Guinn 2001), and it differs from a sanction that changes a firm's behaviour. The corporate exits from Russia lie at the other end: the object was material, the cost to firms was a balance-sheet write-down with no consumer substitution involved, and the pressure operated on producers' accounts, so the flavoring model does not apply. Ben and Jerry's occupies the contested middle: an actual distribution policy in occupied territory, a material object, was carried by a brand whose politics was already a core ingredient of its identity, and the dispute accordingly reached corporate governance in addition to the checkout. The model supplies no verdict on these cases; it provides a vocabulary that keeps symbolic and material pressure distinct.

6. Limitations

The first result must be stated carefully because it limits the instrument it uses. It does not show that political premiums are illusory or that flavoring underlies an apparent sorting. It shows that the two channels are observationally equivalent on market data at the plateau, so that a claim such as "consumers in this category taste their politics" cannot be tested with revealed-preference evidence alone and requires a relabeling experiment. The decomposition is identifiable only by a measurement outside the market, and specifying that measurement is the positive content of the negative result.

The model is illustrative and not estimated. The premium of 0.362, the threshold of 0.443, and the penalty of 0.036 are properties of a stipulated parameterization chosen to lie within the band of the cited effect sizes, and none is a measurement of beer, cosmetics, or any firm. The category dispersions are ordinal stipulations, so the partition shows that a single threshold can generate the received ordering; it does not establish that the dispersion of bottled water is 0.03. The threshold study fixes $\phi = 1$, and the activism study fixes a logit purchase model with a single base spread. Flavoring does not imply fraud or false consciousness. A consumer who tastes the politics has a real experience, since orbitofrontal responses do not distinguish pleasure produced by a price cue from pleasure produced by the wine, and a boycott that targets a genuine supply-chain harm has political-economic effects regardless of its effect on taste. Whether a given act of moralized consumption is taste, tribute, or justice is a question the model sharpens and leaves open.

7. Conclusion

The claim that politics has become part of what consumers buy is true and, as usually stated, untestable, because both sorting and flavoring satisfy it. In a minimal model with both channels, the claim separates into quantities that market data determine (the political premium, the functional-dispersion threshold, and the activism penalty) and one quantity that they do not, the flavoring share of the premium, which requires a blind-versus-labeled rating experiment. Beer and phones differ in their political susceptibility because they differ first in functional dispersion.

Reproducibility

All modelled numbers are produced by `simulation/run_all.py` (population seed 60240, 60,000 consumers), which writes `simulation/output/results.json` and the three figures. Thresholds and break-even points are reported from bisection refinements (`*_exact` fields), with the original grid values retained.

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